

Pazopanib

Pazopanib (Votrient[®]) is a cancer drug. It is used to treat a type of kidney cancer called renal cell carcinoma. It can also treat some soft tissue sarcomas.

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What is pazopanib (Votrient®)?

Pazopanib is also called Votrient[®]. It is used to a type of kidney cancer called renal cell carcinoma. It can also treat some soft tissue sarcomas.

Pazopanib is a type of targeted therapy drug called a tyrosine kinase inhibitor (TKI). These are also called cancer growth inhibitors.

Kinases are important proteins in the body. They control how cells grow and divide. Pazopanib blocks proteins called tyrosine kinases. This stops them from sending signals to cancer cells to grow.

Blocking the signals causes the cancer cells to die.

Pazopanib is also known as an angiogenesis inhibitor. This means it can also stop the cancer cells from developing new blood vessels. This reduces their supply of oxygen and nutrients. This may slow the tumour's growth, or sometimes cause it to shrink.

It is best to read this information with our general information about [targeted therapy drugs](#) and the [type of cancer](#) you have.

Your cancer team will talk to you about this treatment and its possible side effects before you agree ([consent](#)) to have treatment.

More information about this treatment

This information is correct at time of publishing. But sometimes the types of cancer this treatment is used for, or treatment side effects, may change between revision dates.

You can talk to your cancer team if you want more detailed information about this treatment. Or visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) website, which has patient information leaflets (PIL) for individual drugs.

Having pazopanib

Pazopanib comes in tablets. This means you can take it at home.

During a course of treatment, you will meet someone from your cancer team, such as a:

- cancer doctor
- specialist nurse
- specialist pharmacist.

This is who we mean when we mention doctor, nurse or pharmacist in this information.

During your course of treatment, you will have regular blood tests. This is to check that it is safe for you to have treatment. These samples may be used to check:

- the level of your blood cells
- how well your liver, kidneys and thyroid gland are working.

You may also have a urine test before and possibly during treatment to check your kidneys.

You will meet with a doctor, nurse or pharmacist before you have treatment. They will talk to you about your blood results and ask how you have been feeling. If your blood results are okay, the pharmacy team will get your tablets ready to take home with you.

You usually keep taking pazopanib for as long as it is working for you and side effects can be managed. It is important that you do not stop taking it without talking to your doctor, nurse or pharmacist.

If you have certain side effects, or changes in your blood test results, your doctor may tell you to stop taking pazopanib for a short time or to reduce the dose you take.

Taking pazopanib tablets

Your cancer team will give you the tablets to take home. They may give you tablets of different strengths. They may also give you anti-sickness drugs and other medicines to take home. Always take these exactly as explained. This is important to make sure they work as well as possible for you.

You take pazopanib once a day. Try to take it at the same time each day.

There are some important things to remember when taking your tablets:

- Take pazopanib at least 1 hour before a meal or 2 hours after a meal. It is important to take pazopanib **without** food as food can affect how pazopanib is absorbed in the bloodstream.
- Take the tablets with a glass of water, one tablet after the other.
- Swallow the tablets whole. Do not chew, break or crush the tablets before you take them.
- **Do not eat grapefruit or drink grapefruit juice during your treatment.** This can increase the chance of side effects.
- If you forget to take your tablets or are sick after taking them, just take your next dose at the usual time – do not take a double dose.

Other things to remember about your tablets:

- Keep the tablets in the original package and at room temperature, away from moisture, heat and direct sunlight.
- Keep the tablets safe, somewhere children cannot see or reach them.
- Do not throw away unused tablets. Return them to your cancer team at the hospital.

About side effects

We explain the most common side effects of this treatment here. We also include some that are less common.

You may get some of the side effects we mention, but you are unlikely to get all of them. And you may have some side effects, including rarer ones, that we have not listed here.

Other cancer treatments may cause different side effects. If you are also having other cancer treatment, you may have other side effects.

Always tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any side effects you have. They can give you:

- drugs to help control some side effects
- advice about managing side effects.

It is important to take any drugs exactly as explained. This means they will be more likely to work for you.

Serious and life-threatening side effects

Some cancer treatments can cause serious side effects. Sometimes, these may be life-threatening. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can explain the risk of these side effects to you.

Contact the hospital

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will give you 24-hour contact numbers for the hospital. If you feel unwell or need advice, you can call at any time of the day or night. Save these numbers in your phone or keep them somewhere safe.

Very common side effects

These side effects happen to 10 or more people in every 100 people (10% or more) who have this treatment.

High blood pressure

Pazopanib can cause high blood pressure in some people. Tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if you already have high blood pressure before starting this treatment.

Your blood pressure will be checked regularly when you are taking pazopanib. If your blood pressure goes up, it is most likely to happen in the first few weeks of taking the drug. If you develop high blood pressure, you will be prescribed medicines to help control it.

Diarrhoea

This treatment may cause [diarrhoea](#). Diarrhoea means passing more stools (poo) than is normal for you, or having watery or loose stools. You may also have stomach cramps. If you have a stoma, it may be more active than usual.

If you are passing loose stools 3 or more times a day and this is not normal for you, contact the hospital as soon as possible on the 24-hour number. Follow the advice they give you about:

- taking anti-diarrhoea medicines
- drinking enough fluids to keep you hydrated and to replace lost salts and minerals
- any changes to your diet that might help.

They might also ask you for a specimen of your stool to check for infection.

Feeling sick

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will prescribe anti-sickness drugs to help prevent or control sickness. Take the drugs exactly as they tell you to, even if you do not feel sick. It is easier to prevent sickness than to treat it after it has started.

[If you feel sick](#), take small sips of fluid often and eat small amounts regularly. It is important to drink enough fluids. If you continue to feel sick, or if you are sick (vomit) 1 to 2 times in 24 hours, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number as soon as possible. They will give you advice. They may change your anti-sickness treatment. Let them know if you still feel sick.

Changes to your taste

Some foods may taste different or have no taste while you have this treatment. Try different foods to find out what tastes best to you. You may also get a bitter or metallic taste in your mouth. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice. It might help to try:

- sucking sugar-free sour or boiled sweets
- eating cold foods
- eating sharp-tasting fresh fruit.

We have more information about [coping with changes to taste](#).

Tummy pain

You may get pain in your tummy (abdomen), or have indigestion. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice or treatment to help. Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if your symptoms do not go away, or get worse.

On rare occasions, pazopanib can cause a hole (perforation) in the bowel. Contact the hospital immediately on the 24-hour number or call 999 if you have:

- severe tummy pain
- are bleeding from the back passage
- have black stools (poo)
- feeling sick or vomiting
- are vomiting up blood
- have vomit that looks like coffee grounds.

Loss of appetite or weight loss

This treatment can affect your appetite. Don't worry if you do not eat much for 1 or 2 days. But if your appetite does not come back after a few days, or if you are losing weight, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice. They may give you food or drink supplements. Or they may suggest changes to your diet or eating habits to help.

Effects on the kidneys

This treatment can affect how your kidneys work while you are having this treatment. This is usually mild and will go back to normal if you stop taking this treatment.

You will have blood tests to check how well your kidneys and liver are working.

Your nurse may also test your urine for protein.

Contact the hospital on the 24-hour number if you:

- have blood in your urine (pee)
- are passing less urine or peeing less often than usual.

Drinking fluids also helps protect your kidneys. The advice is usually to try to drink at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluid each day. But follow any advice from your doctor, nurse or pharmacist about how much is right for you.

Headaches

This treatment may cause headaches. If you have headaches, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist. They can give you advice about painkillers that may help. Tell them if the headache does not get better, or gets worse.

Feeling tired

[Feeling tired](#) is a common side effect of this treatment. Try to pace yourself and plan your day so you have time to rest. Gentle exercise, like short walks, can help you feel less tired.

If you feel sleepy, do not drive or use machinery.

Effects on the hair

Your hair may lose colour and it may become thinner while you are taking pazopanib. [Changes to your hair](#) are usually temporary, while you are having this treatment. But for some people, hair changes can be permanent.

Sore and red palms of hands and soles of feet

You may get sore and red palms of hands and soles of feet. You may also notice numbness or tingling in them. The skin may also begin to peel. This is called palmar-plantar or hand-foot syndrome.

Tell your doctor or nurse about any changes to your hands or feet. They can give you advice and prescribe creams to improve any symptoms you have. It can help to:

- keep your hands and feet cool
- moisturise your hands and feet regularly
- avoid tight-fitting socks, shoes and gloves.

Your doctor may tell you to reduce the dose of pazopanib or to stop taking the tablets to let this side effect improve. Palmar-plantar or hand-foot syndrome usually gets better after treatment ends.

Effects on the skin and nails

Pazopanib can affect the skin and nails. You may develop a rash and your skin may feel dry and itchy, or it may peel. Some people notice their skin loses some of its colour.

Tell your doctor or specialist nurse if you notice any [skin or nail changes](#). They can advise you about creams or lotions to help with dryness and can prescribe medicines to relieve any itching.

In some people, pazopanib can cause skin to be more [sensitive to sunlight](#). If you are out in the sun, use a suncream with a high sun-protection factor (at least SPF 30) to protect your skin. Cover up with clothing and a hat.

Other side effects

These side effects happen to less than 10 in 100 people (less than 10%) who have this treatment. Some of them are much rarer than this but they are still important to know about. Rare means a side effect that happens to less than 1 in 1,000 people (less than 0.1%).

Risk of infection

This treatment can reduce the number of white blood cells in your blood. These cells fight infection. If your white blood cell count is low, you may be more likely to get an [infection](#). A low white blood cell count is called neutropenia.

An infection can be very serious when the number of white blood cells is low. It is important to get any infection treated as soon as possible. If you have any of the following symptoms, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number:

- a temperature above 37.5°C
- a temperature below 36°C
- you feel unwell, even with a normal temperature
- you have symptoms of an infection.

Symptoms of an infection include:

- feeling shivery and shaking
- a sore throat
- a cough
- breathlessness
- diarrhoea
- needing to pass urine (pee) often, or discomfort when you pass urine.

It is important to follow any specific advice your cancer treatment team gives you.

Your white blood cell count will usually return to normal before your next treatment. You will have a blood test before having more treatment. If your white blood cell count is low, your doctor may delay your treatment for a short time, until your cell count increases.

Bruising and bleeding

This treatment can reduce the number of platelets in your blood. Platelets are cells that help the blood to clot.

If the number of platelets is low, you may bruise or bleed easily. You may have:

- nosebleeds
- bleeding gums
- heavy periods
- blood in your urine (pee) or stools (poo)
- tiny red, brown or purple spots that may look like a rash – these spots can be harder to see if you have black or brown skin.

If you have any unexplained bruising or bleeding, contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number. You may need a drip to give you extra platelets. This is called a platelet transfusion.

Sore mouth and throat

This treatment may cause a [sore mouth and throat](#). You may also get mouth ulcers. This can make you more likely to get a mouth or throat infection. Use a soft toothbrush to clean your teeth or dentures in the morning, at night and after meals.

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number, if:

- a sore mouth or throat affects how much you can drink or eat
- your mouth, tongue, throat or lips have any blisters, ulcers or white patches.

They can give you advice, and mouthwash or medicines to help with the pain or to treat any infection. Follow their advice and make sure you:

- drink plenty of fluids
- avoid alcohol and tobacco
- avoid food or drinks that irritate your mouth and throat.

Effects on the thyroid gland

Pazopanib can affect the way the thyroid gland works. This side effect is usually mild and may not cause symptoms. It will go back to normal if you stop taking this treatment.

You will have regular blood tests to check your levels of hormones that are made by the thyroid. Your doctor may give you drugs to take if your hormone levels are low.

Stroke

Pazopanib can increase the risk of having a stroke. A stroke is a serious, life-threatening condition that happens when the blood supply to part of the brain is cut off. If you, or someone else, thinks you are having a stroke, call 999 straight away.

Symptoms of a stroke may include:

- weakness on one side of the face, such as a drooping eyelid or difficulty smiling
- not being able to raise both arms and keep them up
- slurred speech or not being able to speak clearly
-

- sudden weakness or numbness on one side of the body, including legs, hands or feet
- sudden blurred vision or loss of sight in 1 or both eyes
- sudden memory loss or confusion
- dizziness or a sudden fall
- a sudden, severe headache.

Effects on the liver

This treatment may affect how your liver works. This is usually mild and will go back to normal if you stop taking this treatment. You will have blood tests to check how well your liver is working.

Pains in other areas

You may get pain in your muscles, joints, bones or chest. You may also have pain in the area where your cancer is.

If this happens, tell your doctor so they can give you painkillers. Tell them if the pain does not get better.

Fluid build-up

This treatment can cause a build-up of fluid in the body, while you are having this treatment. This gradually improves if you stop taking this treatment.

Contact the hospital on the 24-hour number if you:

- are gaining weight
- have swelling in your face, legs or ankles.

They can give you advice and treatment to help.

Hoarse voice

You may notice your voice sounds hoarse while on this treatment. Tell your doctor or nurse if you notice this. Drinking plenty of fluids may help.

Problems with vision

Your vision may become blurry. If you notice changes to your eyes or vision, contact the hospital on the 24-hour number. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you advice.

Hot flushes

Some people have hot flushes while taking pazopanib. If you are affected, tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist, who can give you advice on coping with them.

Effects on the heart

This treatment can affect how the heart works. You may have [tests](#) to check how well your heart is working. These may be done before, during and after treatment.

If the treatment is causing [heart problems](#), your doctor may change the type of treatment you are having.

Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- breathlessness
- dizziness
- changes to your heartbeat (palpitations)
- swollen feet and ankles.

Other conditions can cause these symptoms, but it is important to get them checked by a doctor.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain, pressure, heaviness, tightness or squeezing across the chest
- difficulty breathing.

Effects on the lungs

This treatment can cause changes to the lungs. Tell your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if you develop:

- a cough that does not go away
- wheezing
- breathlessness.

You should also tell them if any existing breathing problems get worse. You may have tests to check your lungs.

Tumour lysis syndrome (TLS)

Some people are at risk of developing a condition called tumour lysis syndrome (TLS). The risk is highest at the beginning of treatment. TLS happens when treatment makes large numbers of cancer cells die and break down quickly. This releases lots of waste products into the blood and can affect the kidneys and heart.

TLS can be prevented or treated. You will have regular blood tests to check for TLS. You may have:

- extra fluids through a drip
- medicines such as allopurinol tablets or [rasburicase](#) through a drip.

Drinking at least 2 litres (3½ pints) of fluid a day will also help.

Effects on the brain

Rarely, this treatment causes a brain condition that can be serious. You can make a full recovery from this. But it must be diagnosed and treated quickly.

This condition can cause:

- a headache that does not get better
-

drowsiness or confusion

- changes in eyesight
- fits (seizures).

If you have any of these symptoms, it is important to either:

- contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number
- go to the hospital straight away.

You should not drive yourself to hospital.

Other important information

Blood clot risk

Cancer and some cancer treatments can increase the risk of a [blood clot](#). Contact the hospital straight away on the 24-hour number if you have any of these symptoms during or after treatment:

- throbbing pain or swelling in a leg or arm
- reddening of the skin in the area – if you have black or brown skin, this can be harder to notice, but the skin might become darker
- suddenly feeling breathless or coughing.

Always call **999** if you have:

- chest pain
- difficulty breathing.

A blood clot is serious, but it can be treated with drugs called anticoagulants. These thin the blood. Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information about preventing and treating blood clots.

Other medicines

Some medicines can affect how this treatment works or be harmful while you are having it. Always tell your cancer doctor, nurse or pharmacist about any drugs you are taking or planning to take, such as:

- medicines you have been prescribed
- medicines you buy in a shop, pharmacy or online
- vitamins or supplements
- [herbal drugs and complementary or homeopathic therapies](#)
- recreational drugs – for example, cannabis.

Vaccinations

Cancer doctors usually recommend that people with cancer have vaccinations for flu and [coronavirus \(covid\)](#). They may also recommend other vaccines, such as Shingrix[®] for shingles. These all help reduce your risk of serious illness from these infections. Most people can have these vaccines, including people with weak immune systems.

You should not have live vaccines if your immune system is weak. This includes if you are having or recently had chemotherapy, radiotherapy or other cancer treatments that affect your immune system. Live vaccines can make you unwell because they contain a very weak version of the illness they protect you against. There are several live vaccines, including the yellow fever vaccine.

It is important to ask your doctor, nurse or pharmacist for advice about having vaccinations. They can explain what vaccines are right for you and when it is best to have them.

Contraception

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist will advise you not to get pregnant or make someone pregnant while having this treatment and for a least 2 weeks after treatment finishes. The drugs may harm a developing baby. It is important to use contraception to prevent pregnancy. Follow their advice about:

- what types of contraception to use
- how long after treatment you should continue to use contraception.

You should protect partners by using a condom during sex, even if you have had a vasectomy. This is also if a partner is using other methods of contraception. During treatment and for at least 2 weeks after treatment finishes, you must use a condom during sex with anyone who is:

- pregnant
- of childbearing age and able to get pregnant.

If a partner thinks they might be pregnant during your treatment, contact your doctor, nurse or pharmacist straight away.

Breastfeeding

You are advised not to [breastfeed](#) while having this treatment, or for some time after treatment ends. This is because the drugs could be passed to the baby through breast milk.

Your doctor, nurse or pharmacist can give you more information.

Fertility

Some cancer drugs can affect whether you can [get pregnant](#) or [make someone pregnant](#). If you are worried about this, it is important to talk with your doctor before you start treatment.

Slow wound-healing

Wounds may take longer to heal while you are having treatment with pazopanib. If you need an operation, your doctor will tell you to stop taking pazopanib before it, and for a few weeks afterwards.

You may also need to stop taking pazopanib for a few days if you are having dental treatment or to allow a wound to heal. Talk to your doctor, nurse or pharmacist if you need to have surgery or dental treatment.

Less commonly, pazopanib can cause a [fistula](#) from the bowel to the skin. A fistula is an opening between areas of the body that are not usually connected.

Medical and dental treatment

If you need medical treatment for any reason other than cancer, always tell the healthcare professional that you are having cancer treatment. Give them the contact details for your cancer doctor or cancer team so they can ask for advice.

If you have appointments with a dentist, always tell them you are having cancer treatment. Talk to your cancer team before you have any dental treatment.

About our information

This information has been written, revised and edited by Macmillan Cancer Support's Cancer Information Development team. It has been reviewed by expert medical and health professionals and people living with cancer.

References



Visit the [electronic Medicines Compendium \(eMC\)](#) to download a Patient Information Leaflet (PIL) for more detailed information. The leaflet lists all known side effects.

[Cancer Information Development team](#)

Author

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Our cancer information meets the [PIF TICK](#) quality mark.

This means it is easy to use, up-to-date and based on the latest evidence. Learn more about [how we produce our information](#).

The language we use

We want everyone affected by cancer to feel our information is written for them.

We want our information to be as clear as possible. To do this, we try to:

- use plain English
- explain medical words
- use short sentences
- use illustrations to explain text
- structure the information clearly
- make sure important points are clear.

We use gender-inclusive language and talk to our readers as 'you' so that everyone feels included. Where clinically necessary we use the terms 'men' and 'women' or 'male' and 'female'. For example, we do so when talking about parts of the body or mentioning statistics or research about who is affected.

You can read more about how we produce our information [here](#).

How we can help

How to print a PDF from this website

Instructions on how you can make a PDF version of this page using the print function on your browser.

Clinical Information Nurse Specialists

Our Cancer Information Nurse Specialists are dedicated cancer nurses available to talk to on our Macmillan Cancer Support Line.



Call us free on 0808 808 0000

8am to 8pm, 7 days a week. You can talk to our cancer specialists about anything.



Email the Macmillan Support Line

Email the Macmillan Support Team if you have any questions.

Chat online

Available 8am to 7.45pm, 7 days a week. For confidential, real-time support if you don't want to call.



Online Community

Chat online anonymously to others who understand what you are going through. Our community is available 24/7 and has dedicated forums where you can get advice and ask our experts.



Find cancer support services in your area

What's going on near you? Find out about support groups, where to get information and how to get involved with Macmillan where you live.

Get help